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Emerging Sources, Formats, Channels, Devices, and Audiences in Modern eWOM Communications

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ABSTRACT

This conceptual paper examines how electronic word-of-mouth (eWOM) has evolved beyond traditional text-based reviews posted on online communities and e-commerce platforms to encompass diverse formats, sources, channels, and audiences in today's digital landscape. Building on McLuhan and Fiore's assertion that "the medium is the message," we argue that the characteristics of digital media fundamentally shape how eWOM messages are perceived and processed. We explore four key dimensions: emerging formats (video, visual, interactive content), new sources (digital content creators, virtual influencers), diverse channels and new technologies (social commerce platforms, voice assistants, AI), and evolving audiences (Generation Z, Alpha). The paper proposes a modern definition of eWOM that reflects its increasingly complex nature and discusses critical challenges. We conclude by presenting a framework for understanding how different elements of the eWOM ecosystem interact, offering implications for both research and practice in digital marketing and consumer behavior.

1 | Introduction

Electronic word-of-mouth (eWOM) has transformed dramatically in the digital age, fundamentally reshaping how consumers share and access information about the products and services they buy. The global social media user base has reached 5.22 billion people in 2024, with the average user spending 2.38 h daily across social platforms (Statista 2024a), creating unprecedented opportunities for eWOM dissemination and consumption.

There has been exceptional attention to eWOM from scholars in marketing, information systems, and services (i.e., travel and tourism), including various literature reviews published over the years (e.g., Hong et al. 2017; Babić Rosario et al. 2020; Zheng 2021). Empirical research has proved that eWOM impacts sales (e.g., Godes and Mayzlin 2009; Chevalier and Mayzlin 2006), website reputation (Park and Lee 2009),

consumer behaviors (i.e., purchase intention/decisions) and choice (e.g., Park et al. 2007; Sparks and Browning 2011; Zhang et al. 2014; Filieri 2015), and product evaluation and choice (e.g., Senecal and Nantel 2004; Kim and Gupta 2012). Scholars have also widely investigated the determinants of review usefulness, helpfulness, and adoption (e.g., Cheung et al. 2008; Mudambi and Schuff 2010; Pan and Zhang 2011; Filieri and McLeay 2014; Filieri 2015; Park and Nicolau 2015), and consumer trust and distrust (Filieri 2016; Luca and Zervas 2016).

However, these studies have mostly focused on (a) textual eWOM formats (i.e., online reviews); (b) produced by (often) anonymous sources; and (c) posted on third-party e-commerce platforms or online communities; (d) and adopted by Millennials. The limited scope of the extant body of research fails to capture the rich complexity of today's eWOM ecosystem, where multimedia (i.e., pictorial, video content and interactive formats), emerging technologies (i.e., Artificial Intelligence) and

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new audience segments (e.g., Gen Z) are transforming consumer communication in the digital age.

Building on McLuhan and Fiore's (1967) seminal assertion that “the medium is the message,” and extending Berger and Iyengar's (2013) work on communication modality effects in traditional word-of-mouth, we propose that the characteristics of digital mediums fundamentally shape how eWOM messages are perceived and processed by different audience segments. Specifically, this conceptual work examines how different eWOM formats, sources, channels, and devices shape eWOM message perception and influence. We argue that not only the medium, but also the source, the channel, the device, and the audience collectively shape the message as these communication elements are not “neutral” and can significantly affect the perception and influence of eWOM communications. Building on Berger and Iyengar's (2013) work comparing oral versus written communication, which shows that the mode of communication through asynchrony and self-enhancement influences the products and brands consumers discuss, we explore how emerging digital environments and their unique characteristics impact eWOM effectiveness across various audience segments. We aim to advance the literature on eWOM by looking at the evolution of the digital environment, technologies, its actors, and its users.

This study advances communication theory and eWOM literature by developing a comprehensive framework for understanding how sources, formats, media, and audiences influence the effectiveness of eWOM messages. Specifically, we examine four key dimensions of the modern eWOM landscape: *new sources*: the growing influence of digital content creators, virtual influencers and professional reviewers; *new formats*: the rise of (long and short) video, visual, and interactive forums; *new media and devices*: emerging platforms and technologies reshaping how eWOM is shared and consumed; *new audiences*: distinct generational responses to different forms of eWOM, particularly focusing on how Generation Z and Alpha create, consume, and respond to eWOM.

By examining these dimensions and their interactions, we aim to provide a theoretical foundation for understanding eWOM in the contemporary digital landscape while offering practical insights for marketers navigating this complex ecosystem. This

framework addresses not only current gaps in the literature but also anticipates future developments in digital communication and consumer behavior (Table 1).

1.1 | New eWOM Sources

The evolution of eWOM sources represents a paradigm shift from anonymous reviewers to sophisticated digital content creators. While early research focused primarily on user-generated content from anonymous sources, today's eWOM landscape is dominated by professional content creators who have transformed product feedback into a professional form of digital communication. This transformation is evidenced by the dramatic growth of the influencer marketing industry, which reached \$24 billion in 2023 (Influencer Marketing Hub 2024).

These new sources of communication bring unprecedented reach and engagement, with leading influencers commanding audiences in the millions across multiple platforms. This shift has transformed eWOM from simple anonymous product feedback into sophisticated, multichannel digital content creator professionals. Influencers are individuals who have gained a large number of followers outside of institutional settings (e.g., TV, sports, cinema) (McQuarrie et al. 2013). They have grown a follower base thanks to the informative, unique, and entertaining nature of their rich video content (Casaló et al. 2020; Filieri, Acikgoz, and Du 2023), where they also disclose their life. Some of these influencers are paid by brands to share positive word-of-mouth with their followers (Lee and Watkins 2016; De Veirman et al. 2017). Mega-influencers like Chiara Ferragni have grown a follower base like “institutional” celebrities and have achieved a celebrity status generally enjoyed only on social media channels and among their followers (Campbell and Farrell 2020). Unlike traditional word-of-mouth sources or even earlier online reviews that emphasized informational helpfulness and source credibility, contemporary influencers derive their impact not solely from expertise but from perceived authenticity and relational proximity. Various scholars offer compelling empirical evidence supporting this shift, demonstrating that a vlogger's popularity, homophily, and parasocial interaction are key aspects in deciphering their influence on consumer purchase decisions (e.g., Lee and Watkins 2016; Ladhari et al. 2020).

TABLE 1 | Main themes in the evolution of eWOM communications.

Themes	Key aspects
1. eWOM sources	Shift from anonymous users to professional digital content creators, influencers, and virtual entities.
2. eWOM formats	Expansion from text to rich media formats: video, visual, audio, interactive content, AR/VR.
3. eWOM channels	Emergence of social commerce, live-streaming, voice assistants, and immersive platforms.
4. eWOM devices	Influence of multi-device usage (smartphones, tablets, wearables) on creation and consumption of eWOM.
5. eWOM audiences	Generational shifts from Millennials to Gen Z and Alpha with distinct communication and relational styles, preferences and trust mechanisms.
6. Trust and authenticity	Growing challenges due to commercialization, AI-generated content, and efforts to continuously build credibility, trust, and authenticity.

Although there is vast research on influencer marketing, that is paid brand endorsement, focusing on the impact of their sponsored posts (e.g., De Veirman et al. 2017; Djafarova and Rushworth 2017; Mardon et al. 2018; De Veirman and Hudders 2020; Casalo et al. 2020), there is limited research on influencers' organic eWOM (nonsponsored content) (Filieri, Acikgoz, and Du 2023; Filieri, Acikgoz, Li 2023; Rialti et al. 2024). This distinction between paid influencers' endorsements and independent content creators is critical, as the latter group often focuses on fostering trust and credibility with their audiences through high-quality content (Filieri, Acikgoz, and Du 2023). Furthermore, the overly commercial nature of influencers' communication can create resistance and suspicion among the followers, reducing the influence of their communications. We believe the term "influencers" or "influencer marketing" can be misleading and not necessarily fit the non-commercial nature of eWOM communications produced by many digital content creators.

While digital content creators may incorporate sponsored content, their communications are often primarily driven by their passion, high-quality content, authentic experiences, and emotions. For example, the content creator of *The Pillow* creates content showcasing the lifestyle of individuals who have decided to disconnect from the world and live isolated in remote areas and far from modernity. The motivation pushing this content creator to develop his video is not sponsoring a specific product but rather demonstrating an alternative lifestyle. The sponsor may be introduced during a video by the content creator who clearly highlights the commercial nature of the content and its vital support to keep producing high-quality videos.

Moreover, professional content creators often monetize through diverse revenue streams beyond direct brand sponsorships, such as platform partnerships, merchandising, or subscription-based content. They often have creative autonomy and editorial control, which differentiates them from individuals with brand dependencies and commercial constraints, typical of advertising. Thus, digital content creators can be driven by genuine passion and expertise in specific domains (e.g., tech reviewers, food critics, beauty enthusiasts), while others approach content creation as professional critics or expert reviewers. For instance, Ouvrein et al. (2021) classify digital content creators based on three key dimensions: passion, online admiration, and social media entrepreneurship. They identify passionate business influencers, passionate influencers, celebrity influencers, dreaming business dormants, and passionate topic enthusiasts. This diversity in motivations and business models fundamentally shapes how digital content creators create and share eWOM, often resulting in more nuanced, balanced, and in-depth product evaluations compared with traditional sponsored content.

To summarize, *digital content creators* can be defined as individuals or entities who regularly produce, curate, and distribute original digital content (e.g., videos, images, text, audio) across online platforms, with the primary purpose of informing, entertaining, or educating specific audiences while maintaining creative control over their content production and narrative. These individuals are likely to generate organic, nonstimulated eWOM. We believe this definition encompasses individuals who produce content out of passion. Additionally, it adopts a more

neutral stance, moving beyond the potentially negative connotations of superficial endorsements or the limitations of purely commercial motivations. Unlike sponsored content, where credibility might be compromised by sponsorship disclosure (Eisend et al. 2020), digital content creators often build trust through parasocial interactions, expertise, high-quality content, coherent communications and values, balanced comments, long-term product usage reports, and comparison with alternatives. This approach to credibility building may result in a more authentic eWOM impact compared with traditional sponsored content or anonymous reviews. The transition from casual user-generated content to professional production has blurred traditional boundaries between amateur and professional reviewers, challenging assumptions about the nature of source expertise in eWOM efficacy. In a recent study, Cheung et al. (2025) focus on human digital content creators promoting environmental awareness, sustainable lifestyles, and green products. The authors show that digital content creators' effectiveness in driving eWOM behaviors is significantly enhanced when they develop cohesive relationships with their followers through accumulated social capital. Specifically, content creators' cognitive capital (shared language and common vision about sustainability) and relational capital (trust and reciprocity norms) facilitate frequent social interactions with followers, which reduce uncertainty about green products while evoking positive emotions. This relationship-building process fosters strong relational cohesion between content creators and their followers, ultimately motivating followers to engage in authentic eWOM about eco-friendly products and sustainable practices (Cheung et al. 2025). Therefore, research should probably focus more on eWOM from digital content creators that is not sponsored (e.g., advertising). Research could explore what makes digital content creators' eWOM more effective and in which domains.

Moreover, there are a variety of digital content creators, including opinion leaders, celebrities, journalists, technology early adopters, prosumers, market mavens, and so on. Brand content itself can also be a trigger of eWOM. Furthermore, the industry context could also significantly influence content creation strategies and eWOM effectiveness. For instance, in the technology sector, content creators often focus on detailed information, including product specifications, comparative analyses, and long-term usage reviews. In contrast, fashion and beauty content creators typically emphasize visual storytelling, styling demonstrations, attractiveness, and immediate product experiences. The gaming industry sees content creators focusing on live-streamed gameplay experiences and detailed feature reviews, while travel content creators emphasize experiential narratives and destination authenticity. These industry-specific approaches affect how eWOM is created, consumed, and interpreted by various audience segments. Therefore, scholars should investigate the influence of different types of digital content creators beyond their number of followers (Ouvrein et al. 2021; Rialti et al. 2024), and focus more on boundary aspects like content, engagement, product, brand, or industry types (Filieri, Acikgoz, and Du 2023).

Moreover, research should also differentiate between different types of influencers also based on followers' count, which remains an important topic of investigation (Campbell and

Farrell 2020). For instance, research shows that mega-influencers' eWOM effectiveness can vary significantly depending on brand status in the market. Rialti et al. (2024) found that mega-influencers' positive or negative eWOM messages have stronger effects on consumer attitudes toward market-leading brands compared with challenger brands. Their study, which examined multiple duopolistic markets (Apple vs. Samsung, UPS vs. FedEx, Nike vs. Adidas), revealed that consumers tend to perceive a natural alignment between mega-influencers' status and market-leading brands, making their endorsements more credible and impactful. Moreover, digital content creators come in several forms: they include product-passionate, hands-on individuals who prefer to handle their own repairs and maintenance work (from car fixes to home improvements), cooking enthusiasts who share their culinary creations online, and people who adapt products and services to better suit their personal needs and preferences.

The emergence of virtual influencers (Sands et al. 2022)—computer-generated characters that act as social media personalities—presents a fascinating development in eWOM sources. These artificial personalities, such as Lil Miquela with millions of followers, challenge traditional notions of source credibility and authenticity in eWOM communications. Since the characters have been created for advertising purposes, most research has focused on their effectiveness as brand endorsers, while very little attention has been given to virtual influencers eWOM. The lack of authenticity and the activation of persuasion knowledge may undermine the effectiveness of eWOM from virtual influencers. Consumer responses to virtual influencers' eWOM may differ significantly from traditional human influencers, particularly in terms of perceived authenticity and purchase intention.

Future research should investigate the differences in eWOM impacts among these types of digital content creators, but also cross-industry comparative analyses of eWOM effectiveness across different sources.

1.2 | New eWOM Formats

eWOM can manifest in different formats, such as textual (online reviews), conversational (i.e., questions and answers), audio, visual, and photographic, or a mix of those formats. E-commerce platforms such as Amazon are increasingly encouraging their customers to include images (and videos) in their reviews, as other shoppers would find these more helpful. Research has widely investigated the role and influence of textual eWOM formats, focusing on aspects such as information quality dimensions, review length, readability, and concreteness (e.g., Park et al. 2007; Cheung et al. 2008; Mudambi and Schuff 2010; Pan and Zhang 2011; Filieri and McLeay 2014; Park and Nicolau 2015). More recently, scholars are adopting big data and text analytics to identify specific content in eWOM and its impact on consumer attitudes, behaviors, and business performance. For example, scholars have investigated the role of product and service attributes (Filieri et al. 2021), emotions (Filieri et al. 2022), and sustainability-related topics in online reviews (Mariani and Borghi 2020) using big data, text analytics, and machine learning methods. Recent research demonstrates

how sensory experiences in physical retail environments get translated into online review content and ratings. For instance, Hallikainen et al. (2025) reveal that visual and gustatory sensory experiences have significant positive relationships with online review ratings, while auditory, olfactory, and tactile experiences show more complex patterns. The language expressing these sensory experiences varies considerably—visual vocabulary dominates reviews, followed by auditory descriptions, while olfactory terms appear least frequently (Hallikainen et al. 2025).

However, although content is key in textual reviews, less research has been devoted to new emerging eWOM formats such as video (short and long), pictures, and audio-visual (Xu et al. 2015; Li and Xie 2020; Filieri et al. 2021; Marder et al. 2021). Today's eWOM encompasses rich multimedia formats, including videos (with TikTok reaching 1.5 billion active users), images, live streams, and interactive content, revolutionizing how consumption experiences are shared and consumed online. Babić Rosario et al. (2020) also argue that the older notion of eWOM as a "statement" is outdated and supports the inclusion of formats like YouTube tutorials, Instagram Stories, and TikTok reviews as integral to understanding contemporary eWOM dynamics. Internet users increasingly produce and consume user-generated photos and videos on platforms such as Instagram, YouTube, or TikTok (Filieri et al. 2021). eWOM format is theoretically rooted in media richness theory (Daft and Lengel 1986). According to media richness theory (Daft and Lengel 1986), eWOM formats (and their influence) can vary depending on the communication cues conveyed in the user-generated content shared on these platforms. The multiplicity of cues (Daft and Lengel 1986) in eWOM formats suggests that some eWOM formats (e.g., audio-visual) are richer than others (i.e., textual eWOM) due to the multifarious product-related information conveyed. A format conveying a multiplicity of cues is more effective due to its ability to convey both verbal and nonverbal cues. Research demonstrates that visual cues in eWOM communications (e.g., user-generated pictures) have a stronger influence on consumer intentions and behaviors compared with textual cues (Filieri et al. 2021). Beyond simply including visuals, the content and quality of those visuals significantly affect user response. Li and Xie (2020) identify specific image characteristics—such as colorfulness, human face presence, emotional expression, and photo quality—that influence user engagement. For example, professionally taken, high-quality photos and those containing human faces tend to drive more shares and likes on Twitter, highlighting the persuasive power of visually relatable and aesthetically appealing content in eWOM.

If a picture is a thousand words, a video is a million words because it conveys more communication cues (i.e., motion, verbal, visual, paraverbal). Accordingly, video reviews can be considered the richest eWOM format on the communication media continuum due to the multiplicity of cues conveyed by the source of communication (i.e., audio-visual, verbal, textual) and the immediacy of the feedback, which differentiates it from text-based eWOM. Through videos, consumers can vividly showcase product features and usage, explain how they work, or provide narratives of user experiences, making them particularly effective for building trust and encouraging purchase behavior. The combination of different formats (e.g., video +

text, picture + text, video + picture, picture or text only) can have a different influence on consumer knowledge of products, brand awareness, purchase intentions, and behavior, which is what scholars could research in the future.

Video-based content has emerged as a particularly powerful format, with platforms like TikTok surpassing 1 billion active users worldwide (Statista 2024b), and net advertising revenue has seen a dramatic increase in recent years. User-generated video reviews on platforms like YouTube have also demonstrated remarkable growth. One-third of the time consumers spend online is dedicated to watching videos. Additionally, the number of digital video viewers worldwide is more than 3.3 billion and 89% of consumers confirm they want to see more videos from brands, which helps their purchasing decisions (Bump 2024). Research by Insivia (2024) found that viewers retain 95% of a message when they watch it in a video, compared with 10% when reading it in text.

User-generated videos, particularly short ones, have become a valuable source of information where consumers can learn more about branded products and services (Gan et al. 2023). Academic research has demonstrated that video-based reviews can significantly influence consumer decision-making (Xu et al. 2015). Moreover, user-generated videos provide a unique opportunity for brands to access authentic consumer feedback (Li et al. 2023). Exposure to such authentic content can reduce the perceived risk in online purchasing, particularly for experience goods like vacations, fashion, or cosmetics, where sensory details (e.g., fit, texture, ambience) matter greatly.

Research has further demonstrated that video content quality plays a crucial role in shaping consumer responses to eWOM, with different effectiveness patterns emerging for hedonic versus utilitarian products (Filieri et al. 2020). The impact of video-based eWOM is particularly nuanced in social media contexts, where source and content factors mediate the relationship between social media interactions and behavioral engagement (Onofrei et al. 2022). Moreover, specific elements of short video content—including visual perspective, visual content, and narration appeal—work together to influence travel intentions (Gan et al. 2023).

In addition to videos, eWOM can spread through selfies and hashtags. For instance, hashtags are user-generated metadata tags, typically prefixed by the “#” symbol, that function as content indexing tools on social media platforms (Filieri et al. 2021). They enable users to categorize, search for, and participate in topic-based conversations, thereby enhancing the visibility, discoverability, and spread of eWOM. Hashtags serve both a social function—by linking users around shared interests—and an algorithmic function—by enabling platforms to index and surface content in searches, trending feeds, and recommendation systems. On platforms like Instagram, it is not unusual to observe users posting selfies with branded products in their posts, stories, hashtags, and captions. By doing so, they also convey their attitude or evaluations of these brands through body expressions, hashtags, and captions. For instance, Hartmann et al. (2021) reveal that brand selfies (consumer-generated photos featuring brands) generate more engagement and positive effects than marketer-generated images, with this

effect being stronger when the brands are prominently featured and when consumers' faces are visible. Users can also choose hashtags related to emotions and attitude (e.g., #love, #hate), to experience (#amazing), or hashtags related to a brand (i.e., #Mercedes). These hashtags are used by users to co-create the image of brands on Instagram and other platforms and create a brand community (Stathopoulou et al. 2017).

Live streaming has emerged as another powerful eWOM format, particularly in Asian markets like China. Live streaming is transforming shopping experience combining real-time video product demonstrations with instant purchasing (Liao et al. 2023; Zhang and Ruan 2024). Platforms like Douyin (TikTok) and Little Red Book have popularized real-time product demonstrations and eWOM, creating a hybrid format that combines immediate interactions and feedback with traditional WOM elements. Live stream commerce involves real-time consumer-to-consumer and consumer-to-streamer communication, which is a form of socially generated product information. This synchronous nature of live-streamed eWOM introduces new dimensions to source credibility and message impact that warrant further investigation. For example, Zhang and Ruan (2024) investigate the impact of livestreaming Danmaku—a form of real-time collectively generated comments displayed during a livestreaming show—on consumer purchase intention. They found that consistent Danmaku messages actually reduce consumer purchase intentions through a dual-process mechanism involving psychological reactance and reduced information richness (Zhang and Ruan 2024). Their findings suggest that when viewer comments are too uniform in both content and format, it can trigger skepticism and reduce the perceived value of peer-generated information, ultimately diminishing purchase likelihood (Zhang and Ruan 2024). This counterintuitive effect underscores how the characteristics of new eWOM formats can fundamentally shape consumer responses in ways that differ from traditional text-based reviews.

Moreover, online Q&A represents an emerging format of eWOM, characterized by interactive exchanges on digital platforms—particularly e-commerce sites—where consumers pose product-specific questions and receive answers from other customers or the platform (Banerjee et al. 2021). This format, increasingly prevalent across platforms such as Quora and integrated retail interfaces, enables real-time information sharing that influences both pre- and postpurchase behavior (Heinonen et al. 2018; Khern-am-nuai et al. 2024). Unlike static reviews, Q&As are dynamic, demand-driven, and often expose latent consumer needs through spontaneous inquiry.

Interactive content formats are also gaining prominence, with augmented reality (AR) reviews allowing consumers to virtually experience products before purchase. This evolution toward AR and VR (virtual reality) eWOM formats opens new research avenues (Barta et al. 2025). AR reviews, for instance, could bridge the gap between online and offline retail by simulating in-store experiences. Audio-visual content, interactive videos, and VR could enable users to convey more information about the product being reviewed, for instance, enabling the sharing of more complex information. However, the eWOM literature lacks studies on these emerging new formats, identifying

important gaps that could reveal the variety of consumers' perceptions, attitudes, impacts, and uses of different eWOM formats. We believe that research should investigate how immersive technologies influence trust and perceived value (Kalender and Guzmán 2025), particularly in high-involvement purchasing contexts.

1.3 | New eWOM Channels

Traditional studies of eWOM have largely focused on dedicated review platforms and e-commerce environments such as Tripadvisor, Amazon, and Booking.com, where customers post opinions and evaluations after booking products and services. These platforms were once the primary channels for eWOM, offering structured, text-based feedback that could be easily sorted and consumed.

However, the channels through which eWOM circulates have undergone a profound transformation. The rise of social commerce platforms such as Instagram, TikTok, Douyin, and Xiaohongshu has redefined how consumers express and encounter opinions. These platforms blend content creation, social interaction, and shopping within a single ecosystem. Users no longer visit a separate review site—they encounter reviews embedded in influencer videos, product demonstrations, and comment threads. The result is a form of eWOM that is continuous, ambient, and seamlessly integrated into entertainment and lifestyle content. These platforms collapse the distinction between the act of sharing and the act of selling, turning every social interaction into a potential shopping trigger. Unlike earlier platforms, where eWOM was an endpoint, here it becomes part of the shopping journey itself.

Even traditionally utilitarian platforms have evolved to reflect this shift. Google Reviews, for instance, has grown into a dominant eWOM channel by embedding review functionality directly into tools people already use—such as Google Maps and search results. This contextual and localized eWOM is particularly powerful for small and medium-sized businesses, as it is seamlessly encountered in real-time decision contexts (Filieri et al. 2020).

Beyond consumer markets, a newer category of eWOM channels has emerged within industrial digital platforms, where information exchange is shaped by multiactor ecosystems. Platforms like COSMOPlat enable dynamic interactions between firms, suppliers, and end users, where feedback is not merely evaluative but co-creative. Here, eWOM arises from collaborative innovation and shared problem-solving—embedded in processes rather than posted as opinions (Liu et al. 2025). These industrial platforms illustrate that eWOM can also function as a mechanism of value co-creation, not just reputation management.

Crucially, the nature of eWOM engagement is not uniform across platforms. As Li and Xie (2020) show, the effectiveness of visual content varies based on platform norms. For instance, while the presence of human faces or image-text congruence increases engagement on Twitter, these factors are less impactful on Instagram, where visual content is the default

mode of communication. This suggests that platform-specific affordances—such as interface design, user expectations, and algorithmic visibility—play a significant role in shaping how eWOM is produced, encountered, and interpreted.

1.4 | New eWOM Devices

Moreover, consumers are multidevice owners, and they increasingly use different devices (smartphone, laptop, iPad, smartwatch, smart TV) to retrieve product-related information and to share it. The convenience, ubiquity, and “always-on” nature of smartphones facilitate individuals' eWOM search and sharing through Google and other ancillary mobile apps (i.e., Google Maps), offering consumers greater possibilities and opportunities to rapidly find and share eWOM. Researchers found that customers' eWOM (i.e., rating) behavior differs significantly based on the device they use to post online reviews (Gvili and Levy 2016; Ransbotham et al. 2019; Mariani et al. 2019; Li et al. 2021; Li et al. 2023). For example, Ransbotham et al. (2019) suggest that mobile reviews are more likely to be created during or immediately after service encounters, which affect eWOM content characteristics (i.e., more affective content). Li et al. (2023) show that mobile reviews are generally perceived as less helpful than nonmobile reviews, but this relationship is moderated by review solicitation and reviewer popularity. Accordingly, studies show that different devices shape eWOM creation and consumption.

Additionally, device choice impacts not only content creation but also how users engage with, process, and trust eWOM. For instance, studies have shown that consumers browsing on larger devices, such as desktops or laptops, tend to spend more time evaluating reviews, leading to more deliberate decision-making processes (Wu and Zhang 2024). In contrast, mobile users are more likely to prioritize speed and convenience, often focusing on summary metrics like star ratings or most recent reviews. This divergence underscores the need to study how device-mediated eWOM consumption shapes consumer behavior across varying contexts. Empirical evidence suggests that not only does device choice influence the way consumers interpret eWOM, but it also shapes the very nature of its creation. Reviews written on mobile devices tend to be shorter, more image-based, and more emotionally expressive, often composed in real time and under constrained cognitive conditions (Zhu et al. 2020). Mariani et al. (2023) reveals that the relationship between submission device and eWOM (review valence) is platform-dependent, and driven in large part by platform review policies. Similarly, Ransbotham et al. (2019) find that mobile-generated reviews are generally more affective, more concrete, and less extreme in tone compared with those written on desktop platforms. These content characteristics are not inconsequential—reviews created on mobile devices are consistently associated with lower perceived consumption value, as they are perceived as less reflective and less diagnostic. Over time, consumers appear to internalize these platform-based cues, valuing mobile reviews less even when controlling for content features. Thus, the device used to write or read a review serves as a behavioral and perceptual filter, influencing both the *credibility* and *impact* of eWOM. Understanding these device-dependent dynamics is critical for scholars and practitioners alike,

as they shape both the informational quality of online reviews and their persuasive power in consumer decision-making.

However, more research is needed on the new devices and channels through which eWOM is shared and consumed. For instance, consumer trust and perceptions of eWOM messages may vary across different types of platforms (Lee and Youn 2009; Filieri 2016). However, little research has investigated consumers' perceptions of eWOM channels (i.e., perceived credibility). Consumers may hold different perceptions of eWOM depending on the channel where they are published. Let's take emerging platforms like Temu that only disclose extremely positive ratings (generally above 4, 6) and reviews about the products on their platform, and that continuously push users to shop daily, multiple discounts and offers. This may suggest that the level of trust toward the user-generated content on this and other platforms may be variable. For instance, consumers may trust more eWOM published on Google or TrustPilot rather than on Tripadvisor or Temu (e-commerce). However, apps like Temu are growing their market share and relevance, threatening established companies like Amazon. Different variables can affect the perceived trust and reliability of a medium, such as the reputation of the company (i.e., brand reputation), product pricing, attitudes, the frequency of use, habit, the quality of the information provided, the ease of accessibility, the usefulness of information, the benevolence, integrity and ability of community members, and so forth (Filieri et al. 2020; Chari et al. 2016). With growing types of devices and channels available for consumers to access eWOM, it remains unclear how consumers evaluate these options and whether they are likely to switch among the available options or remain committed to a specific type.

Recent developments have expanded our understanding of how eWOM operates in increasingly sophisticated digital environments. The proliferation of voice-based eWOM through smart speakers and virtual assistants represents another significant development (Flavián et al. 2023). Consumers now share and access product recommendations through voice commands, creating what some researchers term "voice-mediated eWOM". This emerging channel presents unique characteristics in terms of information processing and consumer trust, as users navigate between human and machine-mediated communications.

Research has shown that voice assistants' recommendations significantly influence consumer behavior through different mechanisms compared with traditional text-based eWOM. Voice assistants can create more engaging and natural interactions, leading to enhanced persuasion effects and higher consumer trust (Flavián et al. 2023). The anthropomorphic characteristics of voice assistants, such as their human-like voices and conversational abilities, can generate social presence (Pitardi and Marriott 2021) and emotional connections that affect how consumers process and respond to eWOM recommendations. Furthermore, voice assistants' ability to personalize recommendations based on user preferences and past behaviors adds another layer of complexity to understanding eWOM effectiveness in voice-mediated environments (Flavián et al. 2023).

Beyond voice assistants, emerging technologies such as AR and VR are reshaping eWOM channels (Dwivedi et al. 2023). AR

enables users to overlay digital product experiences onto their physical environments, allowing consumers to share highly interactive and immersive eWOM content (Yim et al. 2017; Soon et al. 2023; Von der Au et al. 2023). For example, AR filters on social platforms such as Instagram enable users to showcase products in real-time, offering both visual and experiential cues that traditional text or image-based eWOM cannot provide. Similarly, VR environments, particularly within gaming or Metaverse platforms (Mladenović et al. 2024), open up new avenues for eWOM dissemination where users can virtually "test" products and then share their opinions within immersive communities.

However, voice-mediated eWOM also presents unique challenges. The absence of visual cues and the temporal nature of voice communications can affect information recall and processing depth, potentially leading to different decision-making patterns compared with traditional text or visual eWOM formats. Additionally, concerns about privacy and the perceived autonomy of voice assistants in making recommendations raise new questions about source credibility and trust in eWOM contexts. Future research could explore how the interplay between channel characteristics (e.g., personalization vs. privacy concerns) and device affordances (e.g., visual vs. auditory interfaces) influences consumer responses to eWOM in these novel environments.

1.5 | New eWOM Audiences

The landscape of eWOM research reveals a notable gap in understanding its varied impact across different audience segments. While eWOM has become a cornerstone of consumer decision-making, research has predominantly centered on Millennials—the first generation to embrace and integrate consumer reviews into their purchasing decisions. These early adopters primarily engaged with traditional text-based reviews on established platforms like Amazon and TripAdvisor.

The foundation of generational differences in eWOM behavior can be traced to generational cohort theory (Inglehart 1977; Strauss and Howe 1991). This theoretical framework illuminates how each generation develops distinct values, myths, needs, and behavioral patterns. A generational cohort represents a group of individuals who are born in the same period of time and have undergone similar social, economic, political, and cultural events during their late adolescence and early adulthood, which have affected their values, beliefs, attitudes, and behaviors (Inglehart 1977; Strauss and Howe 1991). These defining moments form the values, attitudes, preferences, expectations, and buying behaviors of consumers that remain constant throughout the generation's lifetime and constitute a generational identity (Schewe and Meredith 2004).

Communication preferences notably differ across age cohorts, as demonstrated by research in political communication. Iyer et al. (2017) suggest that political WOM/eWOM messages received via different communication modes are perceived differently by age-based voting cohorts in terms of message evaluation, believability, and attitudinal dispositions. Yet, surprisingly, eWOM research has largely overlooked these generational differences in information

processing. Oc et al. (2023) show that consumer-generated comments on a brand's social media video content differ significantly in analytical tone, authenticity, and emotionality based on the consumer's demographic profile (e.g., age, gender, ethnicity).

The evolution of eWOM audiences has taken a significant turn with the emergence of Generation Z and Generation Alpha as influential consumer groups. These digital natives exhibit unique patterns in their eWOM engagement, showing distinct patterns in how they create, consume, and respond to eWOM. Generation Z, with their affinity for social media and influencer-driven content, tends to engage with eWOM through short-form videos and interactive platforms like TikTok, Instagram, and Snapchat (Ameen et al. 2023). Their inclination toward visual and dynamic content presents a shift away from the text-heavy reviews that characterized earlier generations' eWOM behavior. Their preference for authentic, video-based content and peer recommendations has pushed brands and platforms to adapt their eWOM strategies accordingly. Similarly, generation Alpha, born entirely in the AI era, demonstrates unique characteristics in their approach to eWOM. This Generational cohort might be more used to adopting and trusting algorithmic recommendations, failing to spot potential differences in fake and real content, which might lead to a decreased reliability of the recommendations. The integration of voice assistants and smart devices into their daily routines also means they are more likely to consume eWOM via voice-activated channels (Canziani and MacSween 2021), adding a new layer to how reviews are perceived and shared.

Current research faces two significant gaps: the absence of comprehensive cross-cohort studies examining how different generations process and evaluate eWOM, and limited understanding of how older generations like Baby Boomers and Generation X engage with digital word-of-mouth. Addressing these gaps could provide marketers with crucial insights into eWOM's varying influence across generational cohorts. Furthermore, as platforms continue to evolve with technologies like AR and AI, understanding generational differences becomes increasingly vital in predicting and adapting to future eWOM trends.

1.6 | The Issue of Trust and Authenticity

In its early days, consumer reviews stood as beacons of trustworthy information, heavily influencing product decisions and enjoying high credibility among users (Cheung et al. 2009). However, this golden age of trust began to erode as media outlets worldwide exposed scandals involving paid reviews across platforms. Major players like TripAdvisor, Amazon, and Yelp found themselves repeatedly in the spotlight, struggling to combat the infiltration of fake and promotional content. This surge in fraudulent reviews has elevated the reliability of eWOM to a critical concern (Filiari 2016), with ongoing media coverage of industry scandals further intensifying the issue (Luca and Zervas 2016).

This has also affected the new sources of communication like influencers, first welcome as authentic and reliable sources and later found to camouflage sponsored content as nonsponsored

(eWOM). When digital content creators realized their influential power, they started monetizing their posting activity. The attempt of marketing to leverage the perceived credibility of these sources have blurred the boundaries between commercial and noncommercial content (Campbell and Evans 2018). Consequently, skepticism and sometimes deception, have surrounded branded content published by influencers on social media (eWOM) (Boerman 2020). The introduction of disclosure regulations in many countries, requiring influencers to label sponsored posts (Kay et al. 2020), represents an effort to rebuild trust, but the long-term effectiveness of such measures remains to be seen (Evans et al. 2022). Thus, the issue of trust is more important than ever in this context and warrants further investigation (Filiari, Acikgoz, Li 2023).

The significance of this issue is likely to grow with the advent of artificial intelligence, which promises to generate realistic content that mimics human-generated one. As AI technology advances in generating human-like content, platforms race to develop AI-based detection tools (Salminen et al. 2022), engaging in an endless cat-and-mouse game with increasingly sophisticated fake content generators. This underscores the urgent need for research into how different generational cohorts assess trustworthiness across various eWOM sources, formats, and channels.

While scholars have investigated methods for distinguishing authentic from fake eWOM (Jindal and Liu 2008; Filiari 2016; Salminen et al. 2022), significant research gaps remain. Key questions persist about how consumers process AI-generated content, whether its disclosure affects perception, and how different eWOM formats influence trust and product evaluation. Research on eWOM has not fully explored how the formats of eWOM shape the message and how they influence consumers' evaluation of products and services. Accordingly, it would be interesting to compare the different formats to understand what factors influence consumer trust toward textual versus visual or picture versus video eWOM. Furthermore, few studies have focused on the perceived credibility of the medium/channel where eWOM is hosted and the context in which the information is processed. The digital landscape's evolution raises intriguing questions about platform credibility: How does trust differ between traditional e-commerce reviews and social media content? Does the ephemeral nature of platforms like Snapchat impact content credibility differently than permanent reviews on sites like Amazon? Do consumers view AI-generated content differently when disclosed as such? Does the use of AI in eWOM erode trust more broadly, or can it be harnessed to enhance transparency and reliability? To summarize, more research is needed to understand the trustworthiness of different eWOM formats and channels on consumers' behavior in various digital settings. Text analysis of sensory language in reviews may offer promising insights into review authenticity and credibility (Filiari 2016; Hallikainen et al. 2025). Research shows that detailed sensory descriptions, particularly when combining multiple sensory dimensions, can serve as powerful authenticity signals in eWOM (Hallikainen et al. 2025).

Digital identity verification (Shukla and Goh 2024) and blockchain technology has emerged as a potential solution to eWOM

authenticity concerns (Rashideh 2020). Blockchain-verified reviews could create tamper-proof eWOM systems, potentially revolutionizing how consumers verify and trust online recommendations. This approach could pave the way for decentralized review systems where authenticity is algorithmically ensured, reducing reliance on platform-based moderation. These developments suggest a future where eWOM platforms might operate on decentralized networks, fundamentally changing how review authenticity is verified and maintained. In conclusion, trust remains a critical and evolving issue in the eWOM ecosystem. As the digital content ecosystem continues to evolve and new technologies emerge, trust remains the cornerstone of effective eWOM, demanding ongoing attention from both scholars and practitioners to understand and address its complex dimensions.

2 | Toward an eWOM Communication Theory

This conceptual work has discussed how eWOM communications spread across various sources, formats, channels, and devices that different audiences use to improve their purchase decisions. Nowadays, general users, digital content creators, influencers share positive, neutral, or negative comments about products and services and, by doing so, they encourage (or discourage) their usage to their viewers and followers. eWOM continues to evolve rapidly in various digital and technological environments, presenting new challenges and opportunities for researchers and practitioners alike. Our work aims to propose a framework to be used by scholars to conduct research on eWOM in the future. At its core, as illustrated in Figure 1, the theory posits that eWOM effectiveness stems from the complex interaction between five key components: the source (whether human content creators or virtual entities), the platform (spanning e-commerce, social media, and emerging technologies), the format (encompassing text, audio, video, and photos), the device (including laptops, mobile, tablets, and smartwatches), and the receiver (from Baby Boomers to Generation Alpha). Central to this framework is the concept of perceived expertise, trust, and authenticity, which acts as a mediating force between these elements and ultimately influences behavioral outcomes. This theoretical model acknowledges that eWOM messages do not exist in isolation but are fundamentally shaped by the characteristics and limitations of each

component. For instance, a video review created by a trusted digital content creator, shared on Instagram, viewed on a mobile device by a Gen Z consumer, carries different persuasive weight than a text review from an anonymous source on an e-commerce platform viewed on a desktop by a Baby Boomer. The theory suggests that the effectiveness of eWOM communication depends not just on the message content itself, but on the intricate interplay between source credibility, platform legitimacy, format richness, device accessibility, and receiver characteristics. This holistic approach helps explain why identical eWOM messages may yield different behavioral outcomes across various digital contexts and audience segments, providing a more nuanced understanding of modern digital communication dynamics.

While the fundamental definition provided by Hennig-Thurau et al. (2004) remains relevant—describing eWOM as any positive or negative statement made by potential, actual, or former consumers about a product or company available to many people via the Internet—the manifestation and impact of eWOM have transformed significantly with technological advancements. This evolution necessitates a broader conceptualization of eWOM that reflects its increasingly complex and multifaceted nature. We propose the following comprehensive definition:

Electronic word-of-mouth refers to any communication about a company, product or brand that is created, shared, and consumed through digital channels by customers, digital content creators, or other stakeholders, encompassing various formats (text, images, videos, etc.), distributed on diverse platforms, and capable of influencing consumer decision-making through both immediate and persistent interactions.

This definition captures several critical developments in the contemporary eWOM ecosystem. First, it acknowledges the diversity of sources beyond anonymous reviewers, including digital content creators, professional reviewers, and even virtual influencers. Second, it recognizes the proliferation of formats beyond text, incorporating the rich multimedia landscape of videos, images, live streams, and interactive content that characterizes modern digital communication. Third, it reflects the

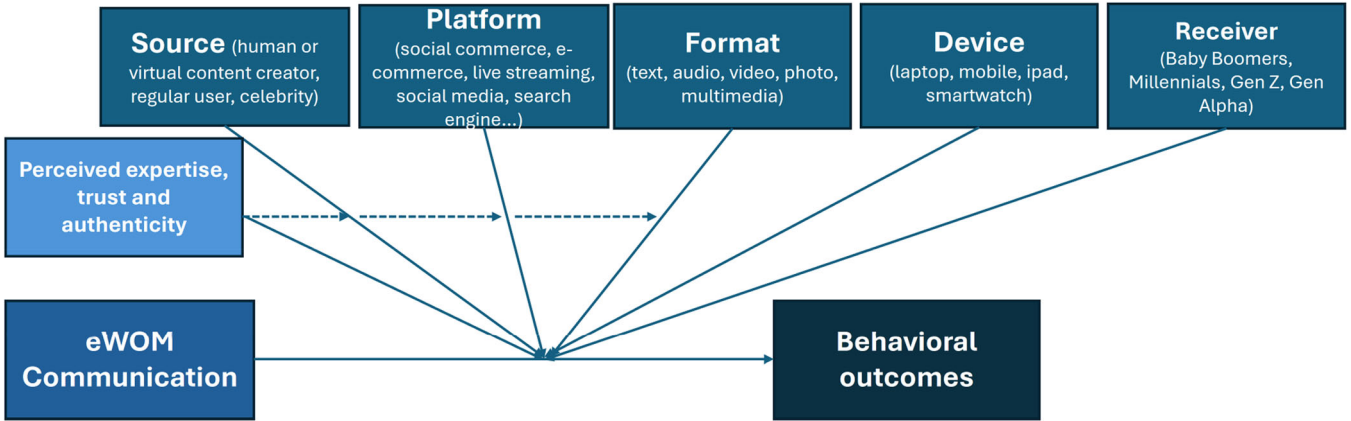


FIGURE 1 | The emerging eWOM communication framework.

multichannel nature of eWOM distribution, spanning traditional review platforms, social commerce sites, and emerging technologies like voice assistants. Finally, it emphasizes eWOM's temporal dimension, acknowledging both its immediate impact through real-time interactions and its lasting influence through persistent digital content.

Moreover, the proposed definition integrates the role of algorithms in amplifying or suppressing eWOM visibility. With platforms increasingly reliant on algorithmic curation, the reach and impact of eWOM are often shaped by machine-learning models that prioritize certain types of content based on user engagement metrics, personalization strategies, and monetization goals. This intersection of human and machine agency introduces new dynamics into the eWOM ecosystem that demand scholarly attention.

3 | Implications for Future Consumer Behavior Research

This multidimensional understanding of eWOM has important implications for consumer behavior in digital contexts. As consumers navigate a landscape populated by diverse sources and increasingly immersive formats, their decision-making processes are becoming both more dynamic and more fragmented. Richer eWOM formats—such as video reviews, interactive AR demonstrations, and livestreams—contribute to higher perceived vividness and immediacy, reducing uncertainty and facilitating more intuitive purchase decisions. In this context, affective responses are amplified, particularly when content is consumed on mobile devices or in time-sensitive environments, such as during in-store browsing or just before purchase.

The evolution of eWOM has also revealed critical challenges, particularly regarding trust and authenticity. While traditional models emphasized platform-based trust and source anonymity, today's consumers increasingly calibrate their trust based on perceived authenticity, expertise, and relational proximity. Content from digital creators who disclose personal experiences and engage consistently with followers is often regarded as more trustworthy than reviews from faceless consumers or overtly commercial influencers. However, this shift toward relational trust also opens new vulnerabilities, particularly when consumers are unaware of sponsorship arrangements or when parasocial relationships override critical evaluation. As the boundaries between commercial and noncommercial content become increasingly blurred, and with the emergence of AI-generated content, maintaining consumer trust remains a paramount concern. Looking ahead, the continuing advancement of digital technologies, including blockchain for verification and AI for content analysis, promises to further reshape the eWOM landscape. For instance, blockchain-based smart contracts could be employed to transparently disclose sponsored content, while AI could help consumers identify manipulated or fraudulent reviews more effectively. Success in this evolving environment will require platforms and brands to balance technological innovation with authentic human connection, while researchers must employ increasingly sophisticated methodologies to understand these complex dynamics.

Furthermore, different generational cohorts process eWOM messages in fundamentally distinct ways. For example, Gen Z and Generation Alpha exhibit a strong preference for short-form, video-based content that is entertaining, peer-driven, and easily shareable. Their interaction with eWOM is more embedded in social media browsing habits than in deliberate search behavior. These audiences tend to assign greater credibility to visual cues, user interaction, and social proof metrics, rather than textual argumentation, in-depth descriptions, or aggregated ratings. By contrast, older generations may remain more reliant on structured platforms and textual reviews, emphasizing clarity, consistency, and platform reputation over media novelty. For example, younger users, especially, may have difficulty distinguishing between human and machine-generated content, which in turn may influence the depth and type of their engagement with eWOM messages. This technological evolution adds further urgency to understanding how consumers discern authenticity and how brands can maintain credibility in increasingly synthetic environments. Future research should explore how different audience segments, particularly emerging generational cohorts like Gen Z and Alpha, navigate these challenges across various formats and platforms. In particular, the ability (or inability) of audiences of different age groups to assess content authenticity is an important area for future research.

The diversity of platforms and devices also adds complexity to how eWOM is approached and processed. Mobile usage encourages just-in-time information seeking, often tied to geographic location or situational needs, making eWOM influence more immediate but potentially more superficial. Consumers accessing content through voice assistants or wearables may engage in hands-free, low-effort processing that favors convenience over deliberation. At the same time, platforms with aggressive curation and algorithmic personalization (e.g., Instagram, TikTok) may reinforce prior brand attitudes and reduce exposure to dissenting or diverse perspectives, leading to behavioral reinforcement or impulsive decisions based on visibility rather than content quality, and other forms of multimedia eWOM should be a focal point, given their unique digital nativity and adaptive behaviors in online spaces.

This reimagining of eWOM reflects its transformation from simple product feedback into a complex, multidimensional form of digital communication that shapes modern consumer behavior. As we move forward, understanding how different sources, formats, channels, and audiences interact within this ecosystem will be crucial for both theoretical advancement and practical application in the digital marketplace. Moreover, this new definition lays the groundwork for exploring how emerging technologies and shifting consumer behaviors will continue to redefine the boundaries of eWOM communication, presenting opportunities for both innovation and critical inquiry.

Ultimately, as eWOM becomes more embedded in multimedia, real-time, and AI-enhanced communication systems, consumers must develop new heuristics and strategies for evaluating credibility and making informed decisions. This requires scholars to investigate not only message characteristics and source cues but also device context, emotional state, platform dynamics, and generational identity—all of which shape how eWOM is interpreted and acted upon.

TABLE 2 | Managerial implications of the emerging eWOM communication framework.

eWOM dimension	Managerial implication
Source	Collaborate with creators based on credibility, expertise, and authenticity—not just reach.
Format	Prioritize visual-rich formats (video, AR) to increase engagement and reduce perceived risk.
Channel	Customize content per platform; align messaging with platform norms and audience expectations.
Device	Optimize eWOM for mobile, desktop, and voice search; consider the context and timing of access.
Audience	Tailor eWOM strategy by generation; ensure clarity for older cohorts and interactivity for younger ones.
Trust	Use transparency, disclosures, and verification mechanisms to protect brand credibility.

4 | Managerial and Policymakers' Implications

As eWOM evolves across a multidimensional landscape of sources, formats, platforms, and audiences, marketers face both new opportunities and novel challenges in harnessing its influence. Understanding the intricate dynamics of eWOM is no longer a peripheral concern; it is central to the strategic design of digital communication, brand positioning, and consumer engagement strategies. This paper's proposed framework offers several actionable insights for managers seeking to effectively navigate and shape the eWOM ecosystem.

First, the diversification of eWOM sources necessitates careful selection and collaboration strategies. Managers must move beyond follower's count and instead evaluate digital content creators based on content quality, domain expertise, audience alignment, and levels of engagement. Distinguishing between paid influencers and independent content creators is essential for building authenticity. Brands that co-create with credible and passionate creators—rather than commissioning superficial endorsements—are more likely to earn consumer trust and foster organic engagement. For instance, research shows that Gen Z reacts strongly to perceived moral violations (e.g., disingenuous endorsements, excessive brand control, hidden advertising), and this cohort tends to avoid influencers and associated brands when they perceive manipulation (Pradhan et al. 2023).

Second, the expansion of eWOM formats demands a shift in content planning. Richer, multisensory formats such as video, live streams, and AR reviews tend to drive deeper engagement and facilitate product understanding, especially for experience-based or high-involvement goods. Marketers must invest in high-quality visual content and ensure that user-generated media is encouraged, discoverable, and shareable across relevant platforms.

Third, the proliferation of channels and devices used to access eWOM has fragmented the consumer journey. This calls for platform-specific strategies. Content that performs well on Instagram may require a different tone and structure than reviews on Google or live streams on TikTok. Moreover, device-specific design—for example, optimizing reviews for mobile, desktop, and voice interfaces—is vital to meeting consumers where they are, both physically and cognitively.

Fourth, the shift in audience composition implies the need for generationally sensitive communication. Younger consumers

demand speed, interactivity, and authenticity, whereas older users may seek clarity and explicit credibility cues. Tailoring eWOM strategies to cohort-specific behaviors and digital literacies—while avoiding a one-size-fits-all approach—can enhance effectiveness and reduce consumer distrust or disengagement.

Finally, the persistent issue of trust and authenticity in the eWOM landscape must be proactively addressed. Marketers must embrace transparency, clearly disclose sponsorships, and consider technological tools—such as blockchain verification or verified reviewer programs—to strengthen credibility. As consumers grow more skeptical and discerning, especially amid the rise of AI-generated content, long-term loyalty will depend on the perceived honesty and ethical stance of brand communications.

The increasingly complex eWOM communication environment also raises important considerations for public policymakers. As consumers are exposed to persuasive content from a growing array of sources—ranging from human influencers to algorithmically amplified and AI-generated voices—the ability to critically evaluate message credibility becomes more challenging and more essential. Public institutions may play a vital role in ensuring transparency and accountability in digital word-of-mouth ecosystems. In particular, regulatory frameworks should evolve to mandate clearer disclosure of commercial relationships, especially on platforms where influencer content and native advertising are prevalent. Additionally, educational initiatives aimed at enhancing digital and media literacy—particularly among older generations and digitally inexperienced users—are essential to empower citizens to navigate increasingly opaque content environments. Finally, as immersive and real-time formats such as live streams, AR experiences, and voice assistants become more influential in shaping consumer behavior, policymakers should proactively examine how to protect consumers from deceptive, manipulative, or biased information in these emerging communication channels.

The following table provides a summary of the key implications derived from the core dimensions of the proposed eWOM communication framework (Table 2).

Data Availability Statement

The data that support the findings of this study are available on request from the corresponding author. The data are not publicly available due to privacy or ethical restrictions.

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